

UX TRENDS: WHAT WE LEARNED

Every topic from the board, one at a time.

UX-CELLENT

5 topics

KEY DECISIONS AND ACTIONABLE NEXT STEPS

Nobody wants to stare at twelve charts to figure out what's wrong. A good dashboard just tells you: "3 orders are late, call these customers." The charts are still there if you want to dig in.

What app shows you way too much data?

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper.

PUPIL DILATION

Your pupils get bigger when your brain is working hard. Some VR headsets track your eyes, so they can notice when you're overloaded and cut back what's on screen. Cool, but that's very personal data to hand over.

Would you let an app watch your eyes?

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper; Kahneman & Beatty, "Pupil Diameter and Load on Memory," Science, 1966.

CUSTOMER SUPPORT TICKET VOLUME (OR DEVELOPMENT REWORK AND COMPLAINTS)

Bosses care about money. If a redesign means way fewer people emailing support with "I can't log in," that's money saved, and it's easy to show on one slide.

What else could prove a redesign worked?

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper.

COMFORT MODE

Instead of checking boxes on an audit, the app hands the settings to the user. Bigger text, more contrast, less motion, and it remembers what you picked. Your phone already does a version of this in Settings > Accessibility. The paper we read says accessibility is a requirement now, and in Europe it's the law.

Which of those settings would you actually turn on?

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper; European Accessibility Act, Directive (EU) 2019/882, in force June 2025.

PROBABILISTIC USER FLOWS

Normal flows are a straight line. Tap this, see that. AI can give a different answer every time, so you have to plan for the good answer, the half-right answer, the wrong one, and "I don't know."

What should an AI app do when it isn't sure?

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper.

PIXEL PERFECT

5 topics

LIQUID GLASS

Apple's 2025 redesign across iPhone, iPad, Mac, Watch and TV.

Buttons and tab bars look like see-through glass. A lot of people said it was hard to read, so Apple added a setting to make it more solid.

Is see-through glass a good idea for buttons?

Source: Apple Newsroom, "Apple introduces a delightful and elegant new software design," June 9, 2025.

A GAUSSIAN BLUR

It averages each pixel with its neighbors so the image goes soft. Designers use it for the frosted-glass look, like the background behind your phone's Control Center, so text stays readable on top of a busy picture.

Where have you seen a blurred background behind text?

Source: MDN Web Docs, "blur() CSS function" (developer.mozilla.org).

A BENTO BOX (BENTO GRID)

Content goes in boxes of different sizes, like a bento lunch. The big box is the important one. Apple uses it all over their product pages.

Find a bento grid on a website you use.

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper; apple.com product pages.

A MULTIMODAL INTERFACE

More than one way to talk to a device: touch, voice, gestures, typing. You ask your phone a question out loud, then tap the answer. It also helps people who can't use one of those inputs.

When would you rather talk than tap?

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper.

CLAMP()

`clamp(min, preferred, max)`. Text grows with the screen but never gets too tiny on a phone or huge on a TV. One line of CSS instead of a pile of breakpoints.

Why is giant text on a big monitor a problem?

Source: MDN Web Docs, "`clamp()` CSS function" (developer.mozilla.org).

CTRL+Z

5 topics

A FLOPPY DISK

Most of you have never held one, but you know it means save. Icons outlive the stuff they're based on. The phone handset for calls and the envelope for email are the same deal.

What would you replace the save icon with?

Source: Wikipedia, "Floppy disk".

A GUI (GRAPHICAL USER INTERFACE)

Before GUIs you typed commands to do anything. Xerox built windows, icons and a mouse in the 1970s, and the Mac brought it to everyone in 1984. Suddenly you didn't need to know code to use a computer.

What's still faster to do by typing?

Source: Computer History Museum, Xerox Alto (1973) and Apple Macintosh (1984) collections (computerhistory.org).

DON NORMAN

He wanted a word for the whole experience of using something, not just the screen, so he took the job title "User Experience Architect" at Apple. He also wrote The Design of Everyday Things. A "Norman door" is one that says pull when you need to push.

Name a Norman door you've fought with.

Source: Don Norman & Jakob Nielsen, "The Definition of User Experience (UX)," Nielsen Norman Group; Don Norman, The Design of Everyday Things, 1988.

A XEROX COPIER

Lucy Suchman filmed Xerox researchers trying to make double-sided copies on their own company's copier, and they kept failing. If the people who build the machines can't use them, the machine is the problem, not the people.

When have you blamed yourself for a confusing machine?

Source: Lucy Suchman, Plans and Situated Actions, Cambridge University Press, 1987.

FITTS'S LAW

Bigger and closer means faster to hit. Screen corners are easy because your mouse can't overshoot them. That's why the Start button lives in the corner and "Buy now" buttons are huge.

Find a button on your phone that's too small.

Source: Paul M. Fitts, "The information capacity of the human motor system in controlling the amplitude of movement," Journal of Experimental Psychology, 1954.

STICKY NOTES

5 topics

EMPATHIZE

Step one of design thinking. Before you build anything, go talk to and watch the people who actually have the problem. The paper we read says user research is still the foundation of good design.

How would you empathize with students before redesigning the school website?

Source: Stanford d.school, "An Introduction to Design Thinking: Process Guide"; Class reading: UX trends paper.

PROTOTYPE

Build a cheap, rough version so you can learn from it. Paper sketches count. If you're scared to throw it away, you spent too long on it. AI tools like Uizard can now turn a sketch into screens fast.

What's the fastest way you could prototype an app idea?

Source: Stanford d.school, "An Introduction to Design Thinking: Process Guide"; Class reading: UX trends paper.

TEST

Put the prototype in front of real people and watch. It almost always sends you back a step or two, and that's normal. Better to find out now than after launch.

Why is it better to fail in testing?

Source: Stanford d.school, "An Introduction to Design Thinking: Process Guide".

IDEO

A design firm that brought design thinking to big companies, schools and governments. They designed Apple's first mouse, and on TV in 1999 they redesigned a shopping cart in five days.

What would you redesign in five days?

Source: ABC News Nightline, "The Deep Dive," 1999; ideo.com.

HERBERT A. SIMON

In 1969 he wrote that design is about changing existing situations into preferred ones. That covers a lot more than making things look nice: a bus schedule counts, and so does an app.

What's one situation at school you'd change?

Source: Herbert A. Simon, The Sciences of the Artificial, MIT Press, 1969.

PROMPT ME

5 topics

GENERATIVE AI (GEN AI)

AI that creates content from a prompt, such as text, images, or code. Designers use it to explore ideas and speed up tasks. Its output still needs to be reviewed for accuracy and quality.

What should you always double-check in AI-made work?

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper.

GITHUB

A platform where people store code, track changes, and collaborate on projects. Designers can also find shared resources, such as icons, interface components, and plugins.

Why would a company give away its design tools?

Source: github.com/about; Class reading: UX trends paper.

VIBE CODING

Building an app by describing what you want to AI, which then generates the code. You test the result and request changes. This can help create early versions quickly, but the code still needs to be checked for errors and security issues.

If anyone can build an app, what makes a designer stand out?

Source: Andrej Karpathy, post on X, February 2, 2025.

PREDICTIVE AI

AI that uses patterns in past behavior to predict what someone may need next. For example, a phone might suggest an app you usually open in the morning. Users should be able to dismiss or correct these suggestions.

When has a prediction helped you, and when was it annoying?

Source: Class reading: UX trends paper.

SYNTHETIC USERS

AI-generated profiles that simulate how users might respond to a design. They can help designers explore early ideas, but their responses may contain biases and cannot replace research with real people.

What could a real user tell you that a fake one couldn't?

Source: Nielsen Norman Group, "Synthetic Users: If, When, and How to Use AI-Generated Research," 2024; Class reading: UX trends paper.

FEELIN' HAPTIC

5 topics

HAPTIC FEEDBACK

Feedback you feel. The little tap when you flip a switch on an iPhone, or your watch buzzing to tell you to turn left. You know it worked without looking.

Which phone buzz do you recognize without looking?

Source: Apple Human Interface Guidelines, "Playing haptics".

PHYSICAL BUTTONS (PHYSICAL CONTROLS)

Touchscreens make drivers look away from the road to find the wipers. A knob you can find by feel is safer. Euro NCAP's 2026 ratings reward cars that bring basic buttons back. Newer isn't always better.

Where else would a real button beat a touchscreen?

Source: Euro NCAP 2026 rating protocols (announced 2024), [euroncap.com](https://www.euroncap.com).

AN AFFORDANCE

What an object lets you do, and how its shape hints at it. A handle says pull, a flat plate says push. On screens, a button that looks raised says tap me. Don Norman made the term famous.

Find something in this room whose shape tells you how to use it.

Source: Don Norman, The Design of Everyday Things, 1988.

HD RUMBLE

Nintendo's very precise vibration in the Switch controllers. In one demo it feels like ice cubes rattling in a glass. PlayStation's DualSense does it too, and its triggers even push back when you pull a bow.

How could detailed vibration help someone who can't see the screen?

Source: Nintendo Switch Presentation, January 13, 2017.

UBIQUITOUS COMPUTING

Mark Weiser's idea that computers would blend into everyday stuff until we stop noticing them. Smart thermostats, watches, doorbells. The paper's section on the Internet of Things is basically this idea today.

Which computer in your life do you forget is a computer?

Source: Mark Weiser, "The Computer for the 21st Century," Scientific American, September 1991.

THE DESIGN OF EVERYDAY THINGS

Don Norman's book about why so many everyday things are hard to use, like doors you push when you should pull. It gave designers words like affordances, signifiers and feedback, and the big idea that when people struggle, it's the design's fault, not theirs.

What's something you use every day that this book would call bad design?

Source: Don Norman, The Design of Everyday Things, revised and expanded edition, Basic Books, 2013 (first published 1988).

WHERE THIS CAME FROM

UX-CELLENT

- \$100: Class reading: UX trends paper.
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- \$300: Class reading: UX trends paper.
- \$400: Class reading: UX trends paper; European Accessibility Act, Directive (EU) 2019/882, in force June 2025.
- \$500: Class reading: UX trends paper.

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- \$300: Don Norman, The Design of Everyday Things, 1988.
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- \$500: Mark Weiser, "The Computer for the 21st Century," Scientific American, September 1991.

FINAL JEOPARDY

- Don Norman, The Design of Everyday Things, revised and expanded edition, Basic Books, 2013 (first published 1988).